TALK THREE

3 The Word Came in the Wilderness

"The word of God came unto John the son of Zacharias in the wilderness."

LUKE 3:2

Luke begins the story of John's preaching by naming the powerful men of the day. Tiberius was emperor. Pontius Pilate governed Judea, and Herod ruled Galilee. Philip and Lysanias ruled nearby territories. Annas and Caiaphas were the high priests. Then Luke writes, "The word of God came unto John the son of Zacharias in the wilderness." John, the man sent to prepare people for the Lord, lived far from where people expected the Lord to appear. To understand why they went out to hear him, it helps to understand life under the men Luke names.

Roman authority reached into ordinary life through taxes, soldiers, and local rulers. Pilate represented the emperor in Judea, while Herod held power in Galilee with Rome's permission. The Jews lived under that government while keeping their own law and worship, and serving God raised hard questions about obeying Rome. A Jew paid Rome's taxes with coins that called the emperor the son of a god. John's message asked them to consider whom they served through their everyday choices.

Alongside Roman rule, the temple's leaders directed the people's religious life. Caiaphas was high priest, but Annas, his father-in-law and a former high priest, still held influence. Luke names them both. Scribes studied and interpreted the law of Moses, and they were often called lawyers. We think of the law of Moses as religious law, which it is, but in ancient Judea it was also the law of the land, the way civil law is for us. It governed worship, work, and relationships. People looked to these men for answers about faithfulness. Then John began drawing crowds away from the usual places of teaching and into the wilderness.

John's way of life set him apart from the leaders in Jerusalem. He lived in the dry, rocky hills near the Jordan River and the Dead Sea, where little rain falls and little grows. He wore camel's hair and a leather belt like Elijah, and ate locusts and wild honey. He needed little from society and did not live to impress the wealthy or make himself comfortable. For people who felt their religious leaders were out of touch with the poor, John offered someone they could listen to and trust. They walked out from Jerusalem and the surrounding towns to hear him, and many waded into the Jordan to be baptized. A traveler who saw the river in 1902, before it was dammed, wrote that its water was "turned to a coffee color" by the mud its current stirred up.

For a poor family in the hill country, a trip to the temple could be difficult to afford. The great feasts meant travel to Jerusalem and days away from home. Sacrifices required animals without blemish, which travelers often bought in the city. Money changers exchanged coins for the temple tax and charged a fee. Those costs weighed heavily on families with little to spare. Listening to John was free. He asked them to repent and be baptized. This gospel didn't charge a membership fee.

John also taught those who had enough to take responsibility for those who did not. When the crowds asked, "What shall we do then?" he told anyone with two coats to share with someone who had none, and anyone with food to do the same. Repentance meant feeding a hungry neighbor. People used to being overlooked could hear that their needs deserved attention. Through John's teaching, they could feel seen by the Lord.

Even people with bad reputations found someone willing to help them change. Tax collectors, often called publicans, collected money under Roman rule and often demanded more than people owed. Many were regarded as dishonest or disloyal to their own people. The Jewish writer Philo described a tax collector in Egypt beating the families of men who fled because of their taxes. Yet when tax collectors came to John, he gave them a way to repent: collect only what was required. Jesus later called one of them, a man named Matthew, from his tax table, and Matthew got up and followed Him. Soldiers were to stop using violence and false accusations to take advantage of people

and be content with their wages. John expected them to change, and he treated them as people who could.

These answers show how direct John was. He did not overcomplicate the gospel or let people's questions about Rome distract them from their own conduct. He did not tell tax collectors to overthrow the government or soldiers to lead a revolt. He told them to stop cheating and mistreating people. Whatever was wrong with the government, they were responsible for how they used their authority. Preparing for the Lord meant obeying Him at the tax table, on duty, and at home.

As John's following grew, religious leaders questioned his authority. We can understand wanting to know who called him. If someone in our town announced that he was now one of the brethren, a large crowd would not be enough to give him authority. But an honest question requires a willingness to hear the answer. John could have told them he held the Aaronic Priesthood, but would they have listened? Jesus described people who looked at John's strict life and said, "He hath a devil." When Jesus ate and drank with people, they called Him a glutton and "a friend of publicans and sinners." Jesus compared them to children in the marketplace who complain that nobody will play their game.

Dismissing John was easier than silencing him, because the crowds trusted him as a prophet. A ruler could not assume they would quietly accept his death. Matthew says that when Herod wanted to kill John, he feared the multitude because they counted John as a prophet. John had no army, but he had the trust of people.

That public trust later put the chief priests and elders in a difficult position when they challenged Jesus. They demanded to know by what authority He taught. Jesus asked them, "The baptism of John, whence was it? from heaven, or of men?" They considered what each answer would cost them. If they said it came from heaven, He would ask why they had not believed John. If they said it came from men, they feared the people, who held John to be a prophet. So they answered, "We cannot tell."

Jesus contrasted their hedging with the faith of people they looked down on. "John came unto you in the way of righteousness, and ye believed him not,"

He said, “but the publicans and the harlots believed him.” John gave people known for their sins the chance to begin again. He also asked respected people to admit that they needed repentance. Isaiah described the preparation John would make with the words “every valley shall be exalted, and every mountain and hill shall be made low.” The lowly could be lifted, and the proud had to come down.

John used the trust people placed in him to prepare them for the Lord. His simple life, his courage, and his willingness to receive people others rejected brought them out to hear him. They learned to share, to act honestly, and to stop mistreating others just because they could. Calling Jesus Lord would ask for this kind of obedience.

The crowds’ question is one we can ask too: “What shall we do?” Have we overlooked someone? Is there something we need to share or a wrong we can put right? I want to be willing to hear an answer that asks me to change, and then do what the Lord asks.

MY TESTIMONY

In my life, prayer has always been something that is great in my eyes because you’re able to freely talk to the Lord about anything at any time. To me, this has been especially apparent recently. The other day, when Brother Hammon talked to us during choir, it really made me start thinking about prayer and how I should try to take it more seriously. Whenever I get into a good habit of praying, it makes me view it more as a blessing or a gift rather than a responsibility or task, and it makes me more grateful for it.

It’s my testimony that praying is how we can ask the Lord what He wants us to do, and that He hears us every time. I share it with you in the name of Jesus Christ, amen.

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